

FREE GUIDE, BY MARIN LAZIC

The Recovery Guide

Match your recovery to the work you did

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BEFORE YOU START

Why the same recovery for everything does not work

Most people recover the same way after everything: a stretch, an early night, maybe an ice bath. It does not work like that. A heavy lifting day, a long run, a week of back to back meetings and a flight each leave a different kind of fatigue, and each needs a different fix. This guide shows you how to tell them apart and what to do about each one, with the numbers.

Strength and conditioning coach to the Australian men's water polo team, and to busy professionals who want to stay strong.

WHAT IS INSIDE

01 Why the rest is where you get stronger, and what happens when you skip it

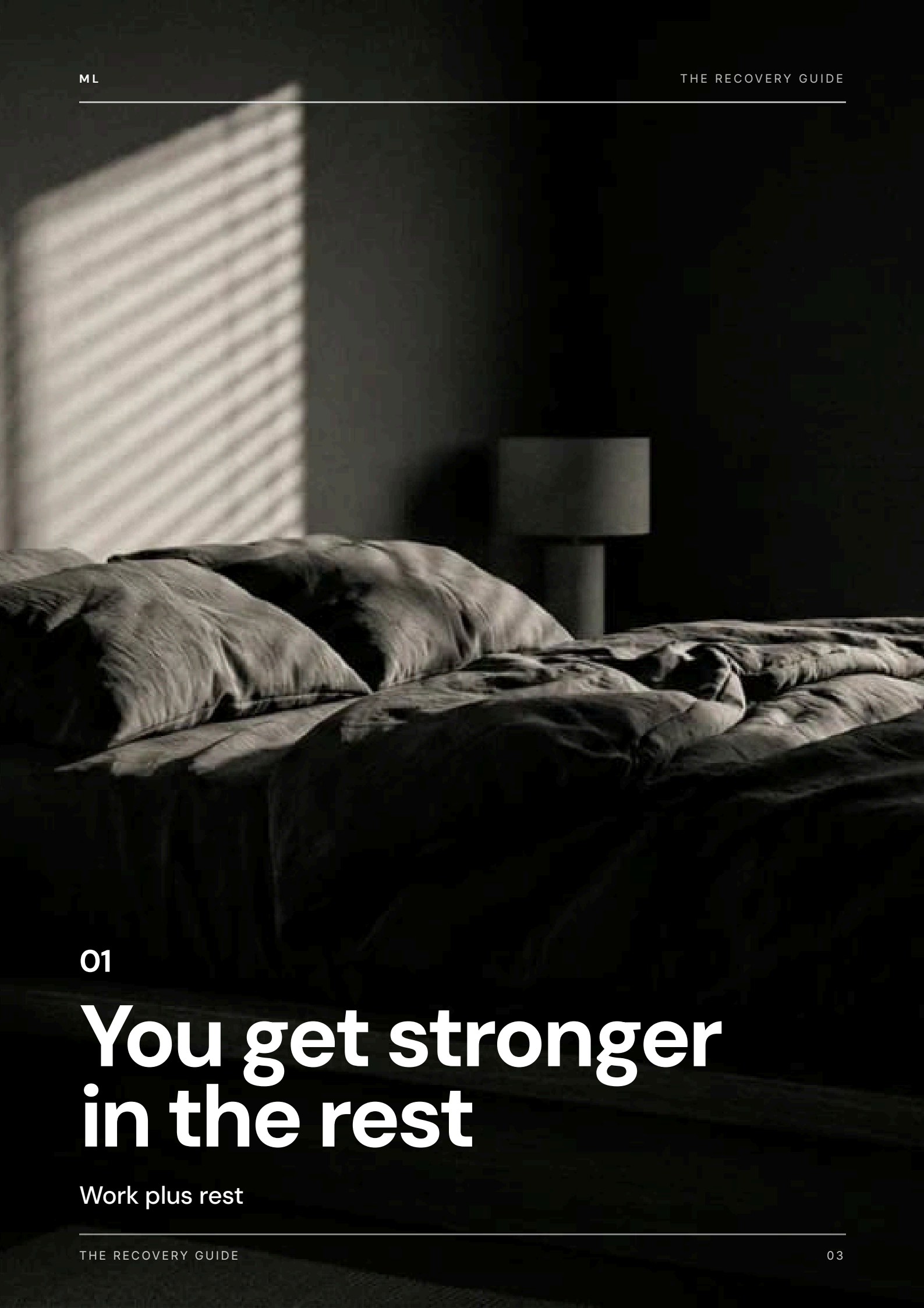
02 The four kinds of fatigue and how to tell which one you have

03 What to do after each kind: cold water, stretching, easy movement, breathing, compression, light and sleep, with times and temperatures

04 The foods that help you repair, and the ones worth a conversation

05 A morning check that takes thirty seconds and tells you what to do today

06 A week that works, laid out



01

You get stronger in the rest

Work plus rest

01 WORK PLUS REST

Training is a stress. The body does not get fitter during the session. It gets fitter afterwards, while it repairs the damage and builds a bit extra so the next session is easier.

That means two things are true at the same time. Work without rest ends in overtraining, injury and illness. Rest without work changes nothing. The result you want sits between them: enough work to ask for change, enough rest to let it happen.

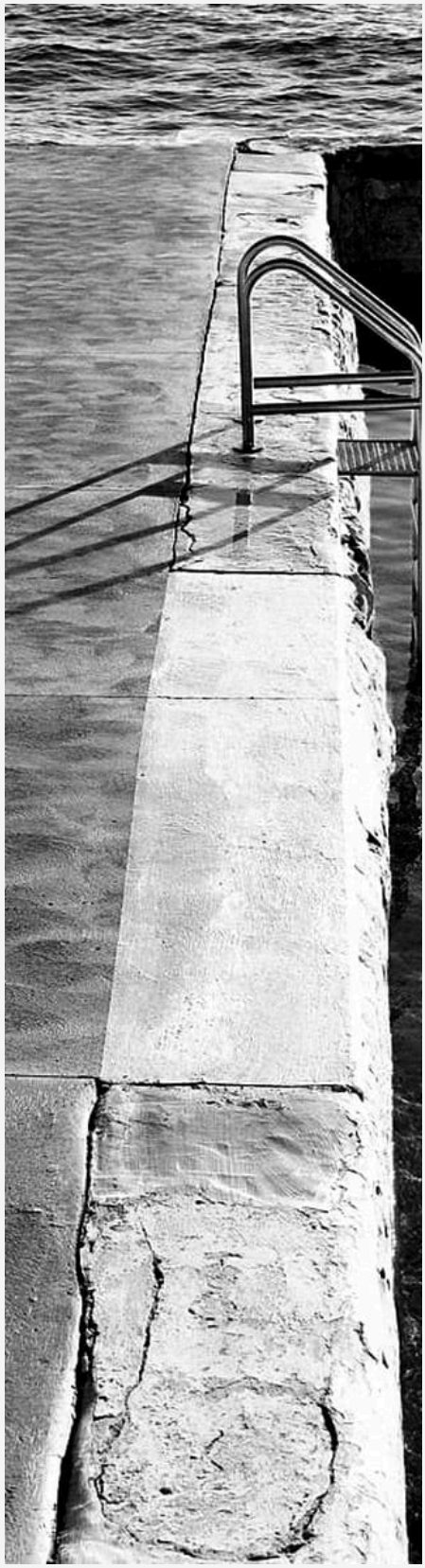
Work → Rest → Adapt

AND AGAIN, FROM A LITTLE HIGHER

Think of it as a loop. Work, then rest, then adapt. Then go again from a slightly higher base. Every time you shorten the rest, you shrink the gain.

THE RULE

Work plus rest equals progress. Miss either half and you are standing still, or going backwards.



02

REST AND REGENERATION

Two kinds of recovery

Recovery is just the process of getting over the stress you put on yourself, at training, at work and at home. There are two ways to help it along.

01 **Rest**

The passive kind. Sleep, food, fluids, switching your head off. It happens inside every 24 hours whether you plan it or not, and the quality of it decides most of your recovery.

02 **Regeneration**

The active kind. Easy movement, stretching, cold water, breathing drills, compression. Planned, put in the diary, done on purpose. A regeneration day is a training day with a different job.

Most people only ever do the first kind, and do it badly. The second kind is where a coach earns their keep, and it is what the rest of this guide is about.



03

FOUR SYSTEMS

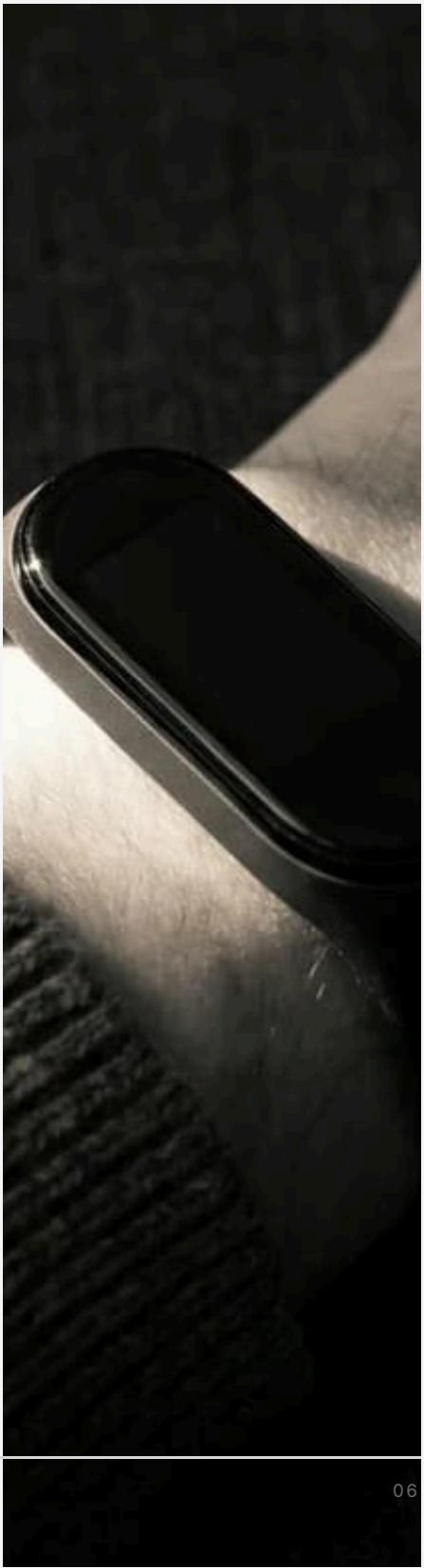
Your readiness changes every day

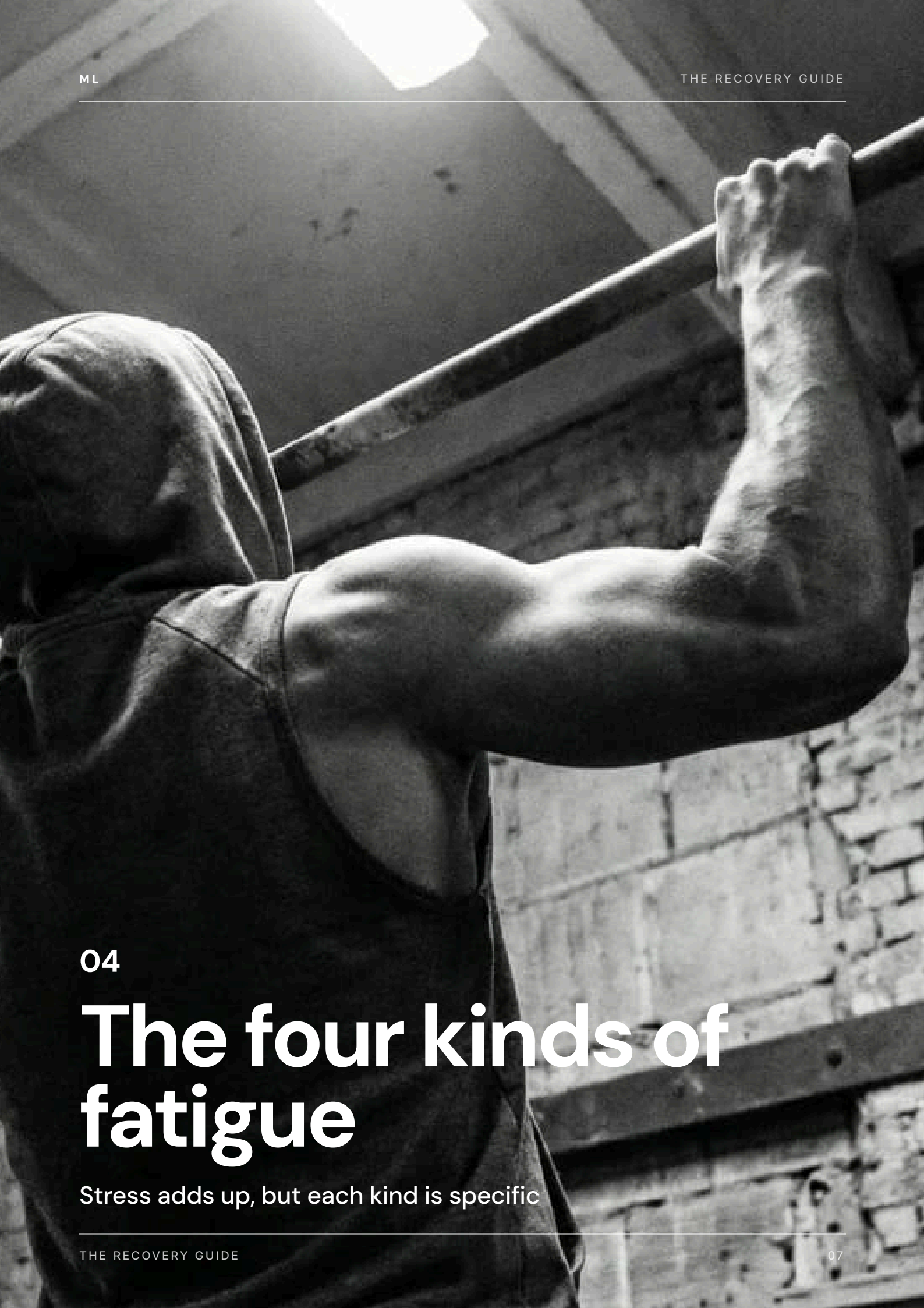
How ready you are to train, think and perform is not fixed. It moves from day to day and sometimes hour to hour, depending on what you did yesterday and what is on your mind today.

It helps to think of four systems, each with its own readiness:

- Nervous system: your speed, power and coordination. Can you move fast and sharp?
- Muscles and joints: the tissue. Are you sore, stiff or heavy?
- Engine: your heart, lungs and fuel tank. Do you have energy, or are you drained?
- Head: your mood and your fuse. Are you calm and clear, or wired and short?

Each system can be fresh or flat on its own. You can be sore but sharp. You can be rested but wired. That is the whole point: once you know which system is down, you know what to fix.





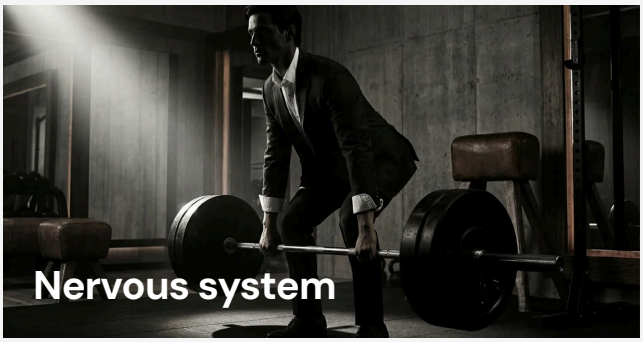
04

The four kinds of fatigue

Stress adds up, but each kind is specific

04 STRESS ADDS UP, BUT EACH KIND IS SPECIFIC

Every session and every hard day lands mostly on one of the four systems. Here is how to tell them apart.



WHAT CAUSES IT

Heavy lifting above about 85% of your max. Top speed sprints. Hard jumping and landing. Low rep power work. Any session where the bar moves slowly because it is heavy.

WHAT IT FEELS LIKE

Flat. No pop. Weights feel heavier than they are. Reaction time is off. You can still grind, but nothing is snappy.

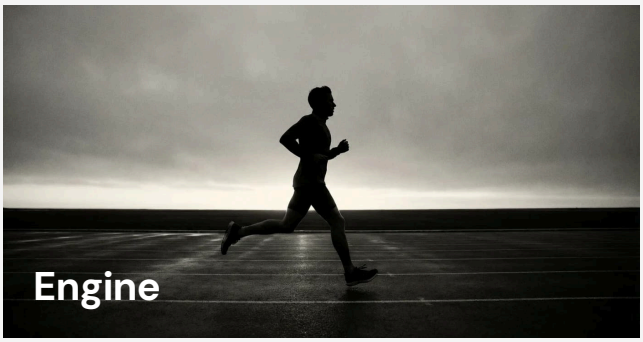


WHAT CAUSES IT

Muscle building work like 6 sets of 6 with two minutes rest. Long lowering phases. Downhill running. Lots of stopping, starting and changing direction. A long flight or a day on your feet.

WHAT IT FEELS LIKE

Sore and stiff. Heavy legs. Stairs are a thought. You move like you are 20 years older for a day or two.



WHAT CAUSES IT

High volume sessions. 3 sets of 12 with a minute of rest. Tempo runs, intervals, long swims, anything repetitive for a long time. A big week of training volume.

WHAT IT FEELS LIKE

Drained and hungry. Breathing hard on things that are normally easy. Sleep is heavy but you still wake tired.



WHAT CAUSES IT

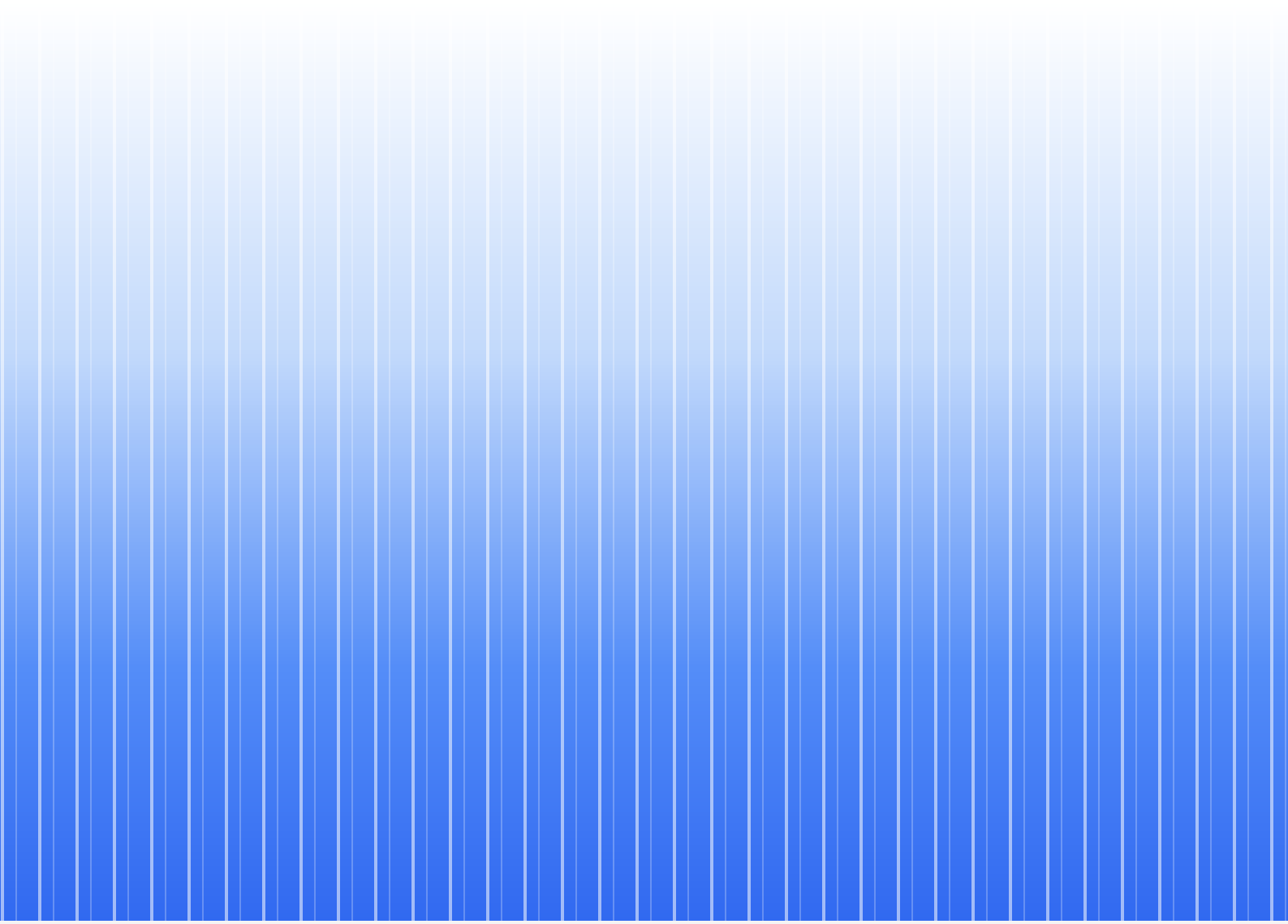
A big game, a pitch, a presentation. A new team or a new job. Conflict at home or at work. Travel. Anything you read as a threat, even a small one. Or things are just not right and you cannot say why.

WHAT IT FEELS LIKE

Wired, not tired. Short fuse. Busy mind at 2am. You skip the warm up and rush the session, or you cannot make yourself start.

FOR THE BUSY PROFESSIONAL

A twelve hour day of meetings is head fatigue with a side of nervous system fatigue. A red eye flight is muscles and joints plus head. A week on the road with bad food and little sleep hits all four. Treat it like training load, because that is what it is.



05

Match the recovery to the fatigue

The part most people get wrong

05 THE PART MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG

We are careful about which system a session targets when we write a program. Then we recover from everything the same way. That makes no sense. Cold water after a muscle building session is a different tool from cold water after a sprint session, and breathing drills do nothing for sore quads.

Pick the list that matches the fatigue. The numbers are starting points that work for most people; adjust to how you respond.

Nervous system

Let the nervous system settle so it can fire sharp again.

10 to 15°

COLD WATER

10 to 15 minutes in a bath, the ocean or a plunge tub.

30 to 60 s

STATIC STRETCHING

1 to 2 sets per muscle. Slow and relaxed, nothing forced.

0

ALCOHOL AND CAFFEINE BEFORE BED

Protect the sleep. Nothing in the hours before bed.

Eat

FOODS THAT CALM INFLAMMATION

See section 06.

Muscles and joints

Give the tissue what it needs to rebuild.

3 to 4

AREAS TO FOAM ROLL

1 to 2 sets of 30 to 60 seconds each. Slow, not frantic.

30 to 60 s

STATIC STRETCHING

1 to 2 sets per muscle.

6 to 8

REPS OF DYNAMIC STRETCHING

3 to 4 movements, 1 to 2 sets. Leg swings, hip openers, thoracic rotations.

120

MMHG OF COMPRESSION

Garments or boots, if the device lets you set it.

Every meal

PROTEIN

Plus foods that calm inflammation.

05 MATCH THE RECOVERY TO THE FATIGUE, CONTINUED

Engine

Refill the tank and repair the working tissue.

20 to 30 min

EASY MOVEMENT

A pace where you can talk in full sentences. Bike, swim or walk; nothing that loads the joints.

3 to 4

AREAS TO FOAM ROLL

1 to 2 sets of 30 to 60 seconds each.

120

MMHG OF COMPRESSION

Garments or boots.

Carbs

AND FLUIDS IN THE HOURS AFTER

Then protein at every meal.

Head

Respond to stress in proportion instead of overreacting to everything.

2 to 10 min

MORNING DAYLIGHT

Within an hour of waking. Outside, not through a window. Caffeine after, not before.

2 min

A HAND IN ICED WATER

Or a cold shower or a short plunge. Practise staying calm while it is uncomfortable.

4 / 2

BREATHING TO SWITCH ON

In for 4, hold for 2, out at your own pace. Or box breathing: 4 in, 4 hold, 4 out, 4 hold.

6 / 4 / 10

BREATHING TO SWITCH OFF

In for 6, hold for 4, out for 10. Five minutes is plenty.

Sleep

THE SAME RULES AS ABOVE

Nothing fixes a head that has not slept.

A WORD OF CARE

If you have a heart condition, are pregnant, or have a history of fainting, talk to your doctor before cold water or breath holds. Start shorter and warmer than you think.

06

FEED THE SYSTEM THAT FIXES YOU

Food does the repair

We sort fatigue by the system it hits, but the body answers all of it through the same two channels: the nervous system that organises the response and the immune system that carries it out. Anything that helps the immune system do its job improves how much and how well you recover. Food is the most effective tool you have for that, and you use it three times a day already.

LEVER	WHAT TO EAT
A healthy gut	Fermented foods most days: yoghurt, kefir, sauerkraut, kimchi, miso.
Omega 3 fats	Fatty fish two or three times a week. Seaweed, flaxseed and walnuts if you do not eat fish.
Omega 6 fats from whole foods	Poultry, eggs, nuts and seeds. Whole foods, not seed oils from a bottle.
Antioxidant rich foods	Cherries, berries, avocado, beetroot, red cabbage, beans, and dark leafy greens like spinach and kale.
Protein	Some at every meal. It is the raw material for every repair on the list.

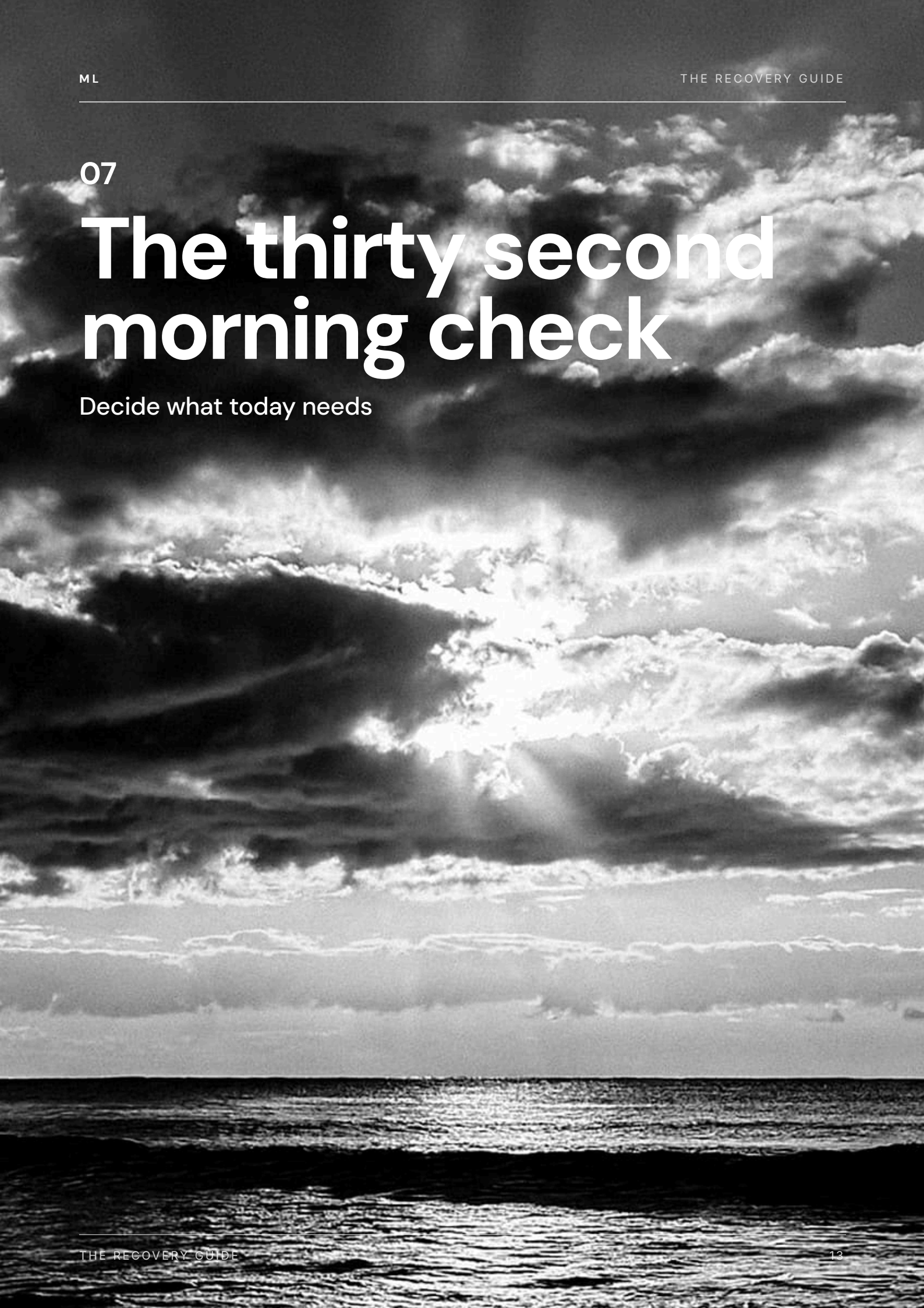
Supplements can help at the margins once the food is right: fish oil, tart cherry, zinc, a probiotic, glutamine. Which ones, and whether you need any, is a conversation for your doctor or dietitian, not a guess from a label.



07

The thirty second morning check

Decide what today needs



07 DECIDE WHAT TODAY NEEDS

Before coffee, score each system from 1 to 5. One is empty, five is fresh.

Nervous system

Do I feel quick and sharp, or flat?

1 2 3 4 5

Muscles and joints

Am I sore, stiff or heavy anywhere?

1 2 3 4 5

Engine

Do I have energy, or am I running on fumes?

1 2 3 4 5

Head

Am I calm and clear, or wired and short?

1 2 3 4 5

1 EMPTY

5 FRESH

Any system at 3 or under gets its list from section 05 today, before anything hard. Two systems at 2 or under means today is a regeneration day: easy movement, the lists, food, sleep. Twenty minutes on the right list beats an hour on the wrong one.

TRACK IT

Write the four numbers in your phone each morning. After two weeks you will see your pattern: which sessions cost you most, how many days you need after them, and what Monday looks like after a big weekend.

JT (B)

STABILITY: TRX CHEST PRESS PLANK HOLDS - 8×10/5

STABILITY: TRX DEEP ROLLOUTS

: DEAD BALL O/H SLAMS "1 BOUNCE" - 3×5

STRENGTH (PULL VERTICAL): WEIGHTED PULL UP 5×6 REPS

THROPY

AGE (FRONTAL): SINGLE KB LAT. LUNGE (L) REACH 3×8 EA.

H (VERT. LOADED): DOUBLE KB SEASAW PRESS 3×8 EA.

BILITY (HIPS): ATOMIC FROG

(HORIZ. LOADED): SINGLE KB SUPPORTED ROW 3×12 EA.

AGE: KB SWING (L) BAND 3×12

BOUND - 2D STANDING (UNLOADED): SIDE PLANK GET UP 3×4 EA.

LOAD. LINEAR

UN-LOAD LINEAR

08

A week that works

3D LOAD

3D - UNLOAD

Put it in the diary

08 PUT IT IN THE DIARY

Here is how it fits together for someone who lifts three times a week, does one hard conditioning session and works a full week.

MONDAY	TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Heavy lower body lift	**Full day of meetings**	**Upper body lift, moderate loads**	**Intervals or a hard swim**	**Heavy full body lift**	**Easy day, family, outdoors**	**Off**
Evening: 10 minutes static stretching, early night, no alcohol.	Morning light before the first coffee. Five minutes of long exhale breathing at the end of the day.	Foam roll 3 to 4 areas. Protein at every meal.	20 to 30 minutes easy walk or spin. Carbohydrate and fluids after. Compression if you have it.	Cold water 10 to 15 minutes if you can get it. Static stretching. Early night.	This is regeneration: a walk, the ocean, sunlight, a proper meal.	Sleep in if you can. Plan the week. Prepare food.

Every day, no matter what: a consistent sleep window, daylight in the first hour, protein at each meal, and at least a 20 minute walk. Those four do more than every gadget combined.

09

NEXT STEP

Where do you stand?

Recovery is one part of the picture. Sleep, stress, training, nutrition and energy all pull on each other, and the weakest one sets your ceiling. My free assessment takes about ten minutes and scores you across all of them, with a report on what to fix first.



TAKE THE ASSESSMENT

marinlazic.com/assessment

If you want help putting any of this into a plan that fits your week, reply to the email this guide came with. I read every one.